

South African Market Q4 2025: Year-on-Year Industry Shifts and Why Quarter-to-Quarter is Misleading

Analysis of Stats SA QLFS microdata | Q4 2024 vs Q4 2025

Executive Summary

Total employment declined by **54,959** jobs YoY to **17.3M** in Q4 2025. Growth was narrow - Transport **+73k** and Construction **+60k** - while Manufacturing **-130k** and Trade **-122k** drove net losses. **Note: Quarter-on-quarter comparisons for 2025 are not recommended due to mid-year weight revisions in Q4.**

Key Industry Shifts: Q4 2024 vs Q4 2025

Industry	Jobs 2025	YoY Change	YoY%	Share 2025
Transport	1,151,328	+73,423	+6.8%	6.7%
Construction	1,437,433	+60,208	+4.4%	8.3%
Manufacturing	1,578,714	-129,571	-7.6%	9.1%
Trade	3,361,646	-122,443	-3.5%	19.4%
Comm. & personal services	4,090,990	+64,064	+1.6%	23.6%
Total	17,311,848	-54,959	-0.3%	100.0%

Full table of 10 industries in appendix

Methodology and Data Caveat

Analysis uses Q4 2024 and Q4 2025 Quarterly Labour Force Survey microdata. Only employed persons Lfs_Status = 1 included. Weights applied per Stats SA methodology. Important: Stats SA implemented revised population benchmarks in Q4 2025. This caused a break in the series. Comparing Q4 2025 to Q1-Q3 2025 will conflate real employment change with weight adjustments. Year-on-year Q4 vs Q4 remains valid as both quarters use consistent methodology at time of collection. For this reason, this analysis uses YoY only. QoQ trends for 2025 should be interpreted with caution. **[Why YoY > QoQ for 2025]**

Stats SA rebased weights in Q4 to align with the 2022 Census. Q1-Q3 2025 used older benchmarks. The +73k Transport gain Q4 vs Q3 would partly reflect reweighting, not just jobs. YoY avoids this by comparing Q4 to Q4.

Data: Statistics South Africa. Quarterly Labour Force Survey 2024: Quarter 4, Version 1.
Statistics South Africa. Quarterly Labour Force Survey 2025: Quarter 4, Version 1.
Pretoria: Stats SA [producer], 2024-2025. Cape Town: DataFirst [distributor], 2024-2025.
Analysis by Gomolemo Bokang Mogasoa. Code: github.com/gomolemobokangmogasoa/repo. Licensed CC BY-SA 4.0.

Appendix: Full 10-Industry Breakdown, Q4 2024 vs Q4 2025

Industry	Q4 2024	Q4 2025	YoY Change	YoY%	Share 2024	Share 2025
Transport	1,077,905	1,151,328	73,423	6.8%	6.2%	6.7%
Community & personal services	4,026,927	4,090,990	64,064	1.6%	23.2%	23.6%
Construction	1,377,225	1,437,433	60,208	4.4%	7.9%	8.3%
Agriculture	940,905	970,263	29,357	3.1%	5.4%	5.6%
Utilities	110,515	133,969	23,454	21.2%	0.6%	0.8%
Finance	3,003,624	2,995,630	-7,994	-0.3%	17.3%	17.3%
Private households	1,168,712	1,147,331	-21,380	-1.8%	6.7%	6.6%
Mining	468,621	444,544	-24,077	-5.1%	2.7%	2.6%
Trade	3,484,089	3,361,646	-122,443	-3.5%	20.1%	19.4%
Manufacturing	1,708,286	1,578,714	-129,571	-7.6%	9.8%	9.1%
Total	17,366,809	17,311,848	-54,959	-0.3%	100.0%	100.0%

Sorted by largest absolute job gains to largest loss.